6BUIS018C – Information Driven Entrepreneurship and Enterprise

Tutorial 1

Introduction

This tutorial will act as an "icebreaker'. You will undertake a series of discussion activities, some of which involves you searching for information and working with others. **Evidence will always be required when presenting your fact and arguments**. We will also use this tutorial to introduce you to the concept of working in your group and working towards the coursework assignments. We will also discuss briefly the first coursework and place this in context.

ACTIVITIES FOR THIS TUTORIAL SESSION

Each of the following is a 'starting point'. Use these topics/points to begin to 'probe' and ask further questions. Consider these as starting points in a 'tree of investigation'. Follow your 'roots' to other 'nodes'.

Part 1 - Consider definitions and descriptions (provide some examples and your reasoning)

1 **What is a business?**

A business is an organised entity that engages in the production or exchange of goods or services to meet customer needs with the objective of generating value. This value may be financial (profit), social, or strategic, depending on the nature of the organisation. Businesses operate by combining resources such as capital, labour, information, and technology to deliver offerings that solve problems or satisfy demand in the market.

From an entrepreneurial perspective, a business is not only a profit-making activity but also a system that identifies opportunities, allocates resources efficiently, and adapts to changes in the external environment. In modern contexts, digital platforms and information systems play a crucial role in shaping how businesses operate and scale.

2 **What is entrepreneur and entrepreneurship?**

An entrepreneur is an individual who identifies opportunities, takes calculated risks, and mobilises resources to create value through new or innovative ventures. Entrepreneurs are often associated with uncertainty, decision-making, and the ability to transform ideas into viable business models.

Entrepreneurship refers to the process through which opportunities are recognised, evaluated, and exploited. It involves innovation, risk-taking, and proactive behaviour, and can occur within new start-ups or existing organisations (intrapreneurship). Entrepreneurship is not limited to launching new businesses

but also includes improving processes, introducing new products or services, and creating social or economic impact.

3 What do we mean by 'information driven entrepreneurship?

Information-driven entrepreneurship refers to entrepreneurial activity where **information and data act as key strategic resources** in opportunity identification, decision-making, and value creation. Instead of relying solely on intuition or experience, entrepreneurs use data, analytics, market insights, and digital tools to guide business decisions.

In an information-driven business model, information is used to reduce uncertainty, identify unmet needs, personalise offerings, and improve operational efficiency. Digital platforms, such as e-Coaching marketplaces, exemplify this approach by leveraging user data, feedback, performance metrics, and algorithms to match supply and demand more effectively and continuously improve the service.

Part 2 – understanding the fundamental measures of a business

1 What makes a successful business?

A successful business is one that consistently delivers value to its customers while achieving sustainability and growth over time. Key indicators of success include customer satisfaction, financial performance, market relevance, operational efficiency, and the ability to adapt to changes in the environment.

Success is not measured solely by profit; long-term success depends on having a clear value proposition, understanding customer needs, effective use of resources, and the ability to innovate. In digital and information-driven businesses, success is also reflected in user engagement, data utilisation, and scalability.

2 How will you know when it is failing?

A business can be identified as failing when it consistently underperforms against key performance indicators (KPIs). Common warning signs include declining revenues, persistent losses, shrinking customer base, poor cash flow, loss of competitive advantage, and inability to respond to market changes.

Non-financial indicators such as negative customer feedback, high employee turnover, operational inefficiencies, and weak strategic direction also signal potential failure. In information-driven businesses, failure may be evident through low platform engagement, poor data utilization, and inability to convert information into actionable insights.

3 **Who makes a successful entrepreneur and what does it take (think traits here)?**

A successful entrepreneur typically demonstrates a combination of personal traits, skills, and behaviors. Key traits include resilience, adaptability, creativity, risk tolerance, and the ability to learn from failure. Entrepreneurs must also possess strong problem-solving skills, opportunity recognition capability, and effective decision-making under uncertainty.

In addition, modern entrepreneurs benefit from digital literacy, data awareness, and the ability to leverage information for strategic advantage. Successful entrepreneurship is not solely dependent on innate talent but is strongly influenced by continuous learning, experience, and the effective use of information and networks.

Part 3 – looking for a business idea

1 **Brainstorm business ideas**

Two potential business ideas identified are:

I. **e-Coaching Platform** – A digital marketplace that connects individuals and companies with professional coaches across areas such as career development, leadership, well-being, and performance improvement. The platform uses information systems to match users with suitable coaches and manage sessions online.

II. **Agriculture Ecosystem Platform** – A digital ecosystem designed to support farmers by providing access to market prices, expert advice, weather data, financing options, and supply-chain connections. The platform aims to improve productivity, income stability, and decision-making in the agricultural sector.

2 **Reflect and critically evaluate some of the ideas (using current knowledge and expertise)**

The **e-Coaching platform** is highly viable due to increasing demand for remote work, digital learning, and professional development. It aligns well with existing knowledge of digital platforms and information-driven business models. However, it faces strong competition and requires trust, credibility, and quality assurance to succeed.

The **agriculture ecosystem platform** addresses a significant real-world problem and has strong social and economic impact potential, particularly in developing economies. While the opportunity is large, it requires deep domain knowledge, strong partnerships, and infrastructure support, making it more complex to implement in the short term.

Part 4 – reflecting on your current strengths and weaknesses

1 **Identify your own expertise, strengths and weaknesses.**

My expertise lies in technology, digital platforms, and entrepreneurship, with strengths in problem-solving, idea generation, and understanding how information systems can be used to create value. I am comfortable working with digital tools and analysing how platforms connect users and services.

However, my weaknesses include limited industry-specific experience in areas such as professional coaching and agriculture, as well as limited exposure to regulatory and legal considerations. These gaps highlight the need for further research and collaboration with domain experts.

2 **Can you identify ideas put forward in the earlier brainstorming session and link to what you might need to do to be in a position to develop further?**

Among the brainstormed ideas, the **e-Coaching platform** aligns more closely with my current technical skills and understanding of information-driven business models. To develop this idea further, I would need to conduct market research, understand user needs (coaches and clients), and explore suitable revenue models and platform features.
The **agriculture ecosystem platform** would require acquiring deeper domain knowledge, forming partnerships with agricultural experts, and understanding rural infrastructure challenges. Given these requirements, it would need more preparation and external support before further development.

Part 5 – looking ahead

1 Can you identify your own new area of interest to develop into your business idea for this module?

Part 6 - Questions and answers

Questions and answers. We may use the application 'Poll Everywhere' to ask students some questions. However, do feel free to raise you queries in class during this session.

Further work

You might like to consider what you have done here and begin to create a 'rich picture' of the sort of things that you begin to consider at the start of thinking about a business idea and what you have to offer – or what you want to get out of it. Later, if future weeks you will build on this.

You would also be well advised to undertake some background reading in support here. Look at the areas that may be applicable in Burn's text that is identified in your Learning Schedule.